SWK 504: GROUPWORK AND COMMUNITY ORGANISATION

GROUP ASSIGNMENT — MEN AT WORK

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https://twc2.org.sg/2026/08/17/the-price-of-working-salary-and-recruitment-fee-survey-2026/

PEER-LED SELF-HELP GROUPS FOR MIGRANT CONSTRUCTION WORKERS

ISSUE AND RATIONALE



- **Employment & Safety Strain:** Essential contributors (~380,000 construction work permit holders from India & Bangladesh) facing pay, workload, healthcare, and safety concerns.
- **Compounded Vulnerabilities:** Poor living conditions, dreadful catered meals, unsafe lorry transport, discrimination, and isolation increase vulnerability.
- **Help-Seeking & Literacy Gaps:** Language barriers (Bangla, Tamil, Hindi) and fear of job loss limit formal help-seeking—79.2% rely on informal peers (Subramaniam et al., 2026).
- **Core Rationale:** **Workers need accessible, culturally responsive peer-led support within their living spaces.**

TWC2 客工亦重 transient workers count too

https://twc2.org.sg/2026/09/03/what-happens-when-lower-skill-workers-are-hired-on-mid-salary-s-passes/

DORMITORY-BASED MUTUAL AID & EMPOWERMENT

PROPOSED GROUP WORK: PEER-LED SELF-HELP GROUP



- **Professional Facilitation (Beginning):** Start with social-worker support in closed dormitory bunk groups (max 8 members) to build psychological safety and circle norms.
- **Native-Language Peer Leadership (Middle):** Train co-workers to lead sessions in familiar languages (Bangla, Tamil, Hindi), fostering mutual aid and shared ownership.
- **Holistic Daily & Rights Scope:** Address daily needs—catered food, accommodation safety, homesickness, worker rights, and local social norms.
- **Dependable Support Network (Ending):** Build a self-sustaining "home away from home" network linking dormitory mutual aid to macro community advocacy (MW-WSP).

https://twc2.org.sg/2026/04/13/dormitories-are-a-secondary-issue-says-twc2-debt-bondage-wage-theft-and-deceptive-recruitment-matter-more/

SOUTH ASIAN MIGRANT CONSTRUCTION WORKERS IN SINGAPORE

THEORETICAL BASIS & THERAPEUTIC FACTORS



Social Support Theory (Hupcey, 1998)

- **Supportive Bunk Networks:** Build supportive networks in a safe, trusting setting replacing disrupted family ties in India & Bangladesh.
- **Reciprocal Social Exchange:** Strengthen confidence to seek, give, and receive informational, emotional, instrumental, and appraisal support.

Therapeutic Factors in Group Work (Yalom)

- **Cohesiveness (Regular sessions, common goal):** Precondition for change; closed weekly bunk circles & shared roadmap forge brotherhood.
- **Universality (Sharing of concerns & solutions):** Validates shared food, housing & remittance struggles; reduces stigma via peer wins.
- **Imparting of Information (Link information & resources):** Connects workers to translated embassy, MOM, TWC2 & HealthServe pathways.

https://twc2.org.sg/helping-workers-in-need/outreach/

INTERSECTIONALITY, POWER & MUTUAL AID IN MULTICULTURAL GROUPS

STRENGTHS FROM DIVERSITY



Different Languages ("Visible" — Bangla, Tamil, Hindi, Telugu)

- **Bilingual Peer Leaders:** Bridge communication gaps and prevent dominant-language monopoly or subgroup exclusion.
- **Safe Spaces & Respectful Dialogue:** Use talking-piece circle norms and basic English classes so every worker is heard.
- **Participation & Shared Decisions:** Promote equal voice and mutual aid across nationalities (Toseland et al., 2004; Muskat et al., 2020).

Different Expectations of Well-Being ("Unvoiced" Priorities)

- **Explore & Validate Differences:** Facilitate dialogue on cultural, religious, and remittance priorities (Crenshaw, 1989).
- **Negotiate Agreed Baseline:** Co-create baseline standards for dietary nutrition and dormitory accommodation safety.
- **Apply, Gather Feedback & Adjust:** Conduct routine bunk safety checks and refine baseline via anonymous voting (ABCD / FII).

https://twc2.org.sg/2020/04/21/covid-19-media-statement-20-april-2020-2/

OUR THANKS

TWC2 & WORKERS | CAFFEINE

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https://twc2.org.sg/2017/06/29/labour-protection-for-the-vulnerable-challenges-and-recommendations/

APPENDIX: SLIDE 4 PRESENTATION SPEAKER NOTES — THEORETICAL BASIS & THERAPEUTIC FACTORS

SWK 504: Groupwork and Community Organisation (Men At Work) | Target Context: South Asian Migrant Construction Workers in Singapore (India & Bangladesh)

Theoretical Framework / Factor	Core Concepts & Slide 4 Anchor	Application to Indian & Bangladeshi Construction Workers	Key Defense Highlights & Evidence
Social Support Theory (Hupcey, 1998)	**4 Core Concepts:** Relationships (network), Perception of support, Receiving support, Social exchange. **4 Functions:** Informational, Emotional, Instrumental, Appraisal.	**Rebuilding Disrupted Kinship Ties:** Leaving immediate family in India & Bangladesh removes natural kinship buffers. Closed dormitory bunk circles create a safe setting for *reciprocal social exchange*—seeking, giving, and receiving empathy in Bangla/Tamil, rights literacy, daily food/bunk checks, and dignity affirmation.	**79.2%** of migrant workers seek emotional help from informal peer/family networks; **39.7%** prefer a trained fellow worker & **69.1%** prefer face-to-face workshops (Subramaniam et al., 2026).
1. Group Cohesiveness (Yalom & Leszcz, 2020)	*Slide Anchor:* Regular sessions, common goal. Precondition enabling all other therapeutic factors to operate.	**Forging a Bunk "Brotherhood":** Weekly sessions within the same dormitory bunk (max 8 members), guided by talking-piece circle norms and a shared well-being roadmap, bridge linguistic sub-groups (Bangla vs. Tamil/Hindi).	Overcomes interpersonal distrust, fear of community gossip/reputation loss, and workplace isolation to build a dependable *"home away from home."*
2. Universality (Yalom & Leszcz, 2020)	*Slide Anchor:* Sharing of concerns & solutions. Disconfirms unique isolation (*"in the same boat"*).	**Collective Validation:** Members openly voice struggles over dreadful catered meals, overcrowded bunks, unsafe lorry transport, and family remittance pressure while exchanging successful peer coping strategies.	Transforms stoic self-reliance and cultural stigma around mental distress (fear of being labeled *"mad"*) into shared structural understanding and mutual aid.
3. Imparting of Information (Yalom & Leszcz, 2020)	*Slide Anchor:* Link information & resources. Didactic guidance & peer resource navigation.	**Closing the "Outsider" Literacy Gap:** Social workers and bilingual peer leaders demystify local norms, employment laws, and healthcare coverage under the mandatory Primary Care Plan (PCP).	Connects workers directly to translated resources via High Commissions/Embassies, MOM (FWMOMCare/SnapSAFE), TWC2, and Project DAWN / HealthServe.

Verbatim Presentation Delivery Script for Slide 4 (~60–75 Seconds)

[Theoretical Basis — Social Support Theory (Hupcey, 1998)]: *"Moving to Slide 4, our groupwork design is anchored in Hupcey's (1998) Social Support Theory. When Indian and Bangladeshi construction workers arrive in Singapore, their immediate family networks are disrupted, leaving them isolated in dormitories while navigating wage, food, and safety pressures. Local research by Subramaniam et al. (2026) shows that 79.2% of migrant workers turn to informal peer networks for emotional problems because fear of job loss, mental health stigma, and language barriers deter them from formal clinics. Applying Hupcey's framework, our bunk-based self-help group establishes a safe setting where workers engage in reciprocal social exchange—actively seeking, giving, and receiving emotional empathy in Bangla and Tamil, informational guidance on local norms and worker rights, instrumental daily problem-solving, and appraisal affirmation of their dignity."*

[Therapeutic Factors — Yalom (Cohesiveness, Universality, Information)]: *"To operationalize this theory inside the group, we intentionally promote three of Yalom's therapeutic factors: First, Group Cohesiveness—the precondition for all group change. Through regular weekly sessions in their dormitory bunk and working toward a common well-being roadmap, members bridge language divides to build a dependable 'home away from home.' Second, Universality. By inviting every member to voice concerns over food or accommodation and share successful coping efforts, workers realize they are in the same boat—transforming silent, stoic isolation into mutual validation. Third, Imparting of Information. Facilitators and trained peer leaders link workers directly to translated resources from embassies, MOM, TWC2, and HealthServe—equipping them with actionable pathways to safeguard their well-being."*